I work in accounting software. Recently, one of my company's servers failed. The server monitoring failed to pick it up because the monitoring software was not running. Therefore multiple customers – large and small businesses - were unable to access the software for a short time. Following reports of the outage from our customers, situation was quickly resolved. The time taken for our reputation to recover with those customers was much longer. The internal investigations led to an improved "playbook" to ensure there could be no repeat of this event.

In my working lifetime, I've moved from recording accounting transactions on paper, to recording them on a standalone PC, to entering them on a cloud based platform. The reliance for backups and accessibility now lies with an outside contractor. The swiftness of this change – it's taken around 20 years for small companies to leave behind centuries of using hand-written ledgers, to them being able to access cloud based, multi-featured solutions - demonstrates that this is the 4th Industrial revolution due to its "velocity, scope, and systems impact". (Schwab 2016)

Both Schwab (2016) and Metcalf (2024) speak about the challenges faced by governments to keep pace with regulating new technologies, but I believe this is also true for internal governance in companies using new technologies.

References:
Schwab, K. (2016) *The Fourth Industrial Revolution: what it means, how to respond*. Available at: **https://www.weforum.org/stories/technological-innovation/the-fourth-industrial-revolution-what-it-means-and-how-to-respond/** (Accessed: 09 August 2026).

Metcalf, G.S. (2024) 'An introduction to Industry 5.0: history, foundations, and futures', in Nousala, S., Metcalf, G. and Ing, D. (eds) *Industry 4.0 to Industry 5.0: explorations in the transition from a techno-economic to a socio-technical future*. Singapore: Springer, pp. 1-30. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-99-9730-5_1 (Accessed: 09 August 2026)

Thoughts and Notes

- one source of truth, uneditable, once lost, it's gone. Done that way for centuries. To computer transactions on a local, standalone PC, where nightly backups would be taken and stored off-site (taken home by the accountant), to cloud systems on multi-tenanted platforms, where the reliance for backups and accessibility lies with an outside contractor. The swiftness of this change – centuries of hand-written ledgers, to transactions logged on a standalone PC to cloud based, multi-tenanted solutions within 20 years demonstrates that this is the 4th Industrial revolution due to its velocity, scope, and systems impact (Schwab 2016)

The 4th Industrial revolution has made real-time transactional recording and reporting accessible to companies of all size – including sole traders.

Recently, one of my company's servers failed. The server monitoring failed to pick it up as, last time the server was restarted, the monitoring software was not restarted. Therefore multiple customers were unable to access the software, unable to process invoices, unable to pay suppliers for a short time. Following reports of the outage from our customers, the server was rebooted and the monitoring software was also restarted. The time taken for our reputation to

recover with those customers was much longer. The internal investigations led to an improved "playbook" to ensure such a monitoring failure could not happen in the future.

Schwab, K. (2016) *The Fourth Industrial Revolution: what it means, how to respond*. Available at: **https://www.weforum.org/stories/technological-innovation/the-fourth-industrial-revolution-what-it-means-and-how-to-respond/** (Accessed: 09 August 2026).

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